“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 2

The Punishment of Choṭa Haridāsa

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I bow down to the beautiful lotus feet of my śrī guru, to the śrī gurus and to the Vaiṣṇavas; to Śrī Rūpa, together with his elder brother (Sanātana), with Raghunātha and his companions and with Jīva; to Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanyadeva, together with Advaita, with the Avadhūta (Nityānanda) and with His associates; and to the feet of Śrī Rādhā and Kṛṣṇa, together with Their companions, Lalitā and Śrī Viśākhā.

2 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra! Glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

3 Gaura descended to deliver all the worlds, and the means by which He delivered them were of three kinds.

4 He delivered by being seen in person; and in some places He made His ‘āveśa’, entering a worthy devotee, and in others He delivered by His ‘āvirbhāva’, appearing Himself.

5 By being seen in person He delivered almost everyone; and He ‘entered’ the body of Nakula Brahmacārī.

6 Before Pradyumna Nṛsiṁhānanda He made His ‘āvirbhāva’ (appeared). “I shall deliver the people” — such is the nature of the Lord.

7 By being seen in person He delivered the whole world: whoever saw Him even once attained the goal of life.

8 Every year the devotees of Gauḍa would come, meet the Lord and go back again to Gauḍa.

9 And people from many lands came to Jagannātha; seeing Caitanya's feet, they attained the goal of life.

10 People of the seven dvīpas (islands) and dwellers of the nine khaṇḍas (regions) — devas, gandharvas and kinnaras — came in human guise.

11 Seeing the Lord, they went away as Vaiṣṇavas; crying "Kṛṣṇa!", they all danced, overwhelmed by prema.

12 In this way, by being seen, He delivered the three worlds. But there were many worldly people who could not come.

13 To deliver them, in all those lands the Lord made His 'āveśa', entering the bodies of worthy devotees.

14 In that soul He manifests His own power, and by seeing him people in every land become Vaiṣṇavas.

15 Thus, by His āveśa, He delivered the three worlds. I shall show in brief, as an example, how His āveśa took place in Gauḍa.

16 In the district of Āmbuyā lived Nakula Brahmacārī, a supreme Vaiṣṇava of very high standing.

17 Wishing to deliver the people of Gauḍa, the Lord made His 'āveśa' in Nakula's heart.

18 Overwhelmed by prema, Nakula became as if possessed by a spirit: like a madman he laughed, wept, danced and sang.

19 Tears, trembling, stupor and perspiration — the sāttvika transformations — appeared in him; in prema he danced constantly and roared again and again.

20 He had the same golden lustre as the Lord and the same constant absorption in prema, and all Gauḍa came to see it.

21 To everyone he saw he said, “Say the name of Kṛṣṇa!” And by seeing him the people became wild with prema.

22 Hearing that Caitanya had entered Nakula’s body, Śivānanda came, doubting it.

23 Wishing to test him, he stayed outside and reflected:

24–25 “If he calls me himself — if I see that — and, knowing my iṣṭa-mantra, tells it to me himself, then I shall know that Caitanya has entered him.” Thinking thus, Śivānanda stayed at a distance.

26 There was a vast throng of people, some coming, some going; in the press of the crowd some could not even see him.

27 The brahmacārī said, “Śivānanda is standing far off. Two or four of you go and call him.”

28 The people ran in every direction, crying, “Śivānanda! Who is Śivānanda? The brahmacārī is calling you!”

29 Hearing this, Śivānanda Sena quickly came there, offered his obeisances and sat down near him.

30 The brahmacārī said, “You have doubted. Now listen with undivided attention, and be certain:

31 your ‘Gaura-Gopāla mantra’ has four syllables. Give up the disbelief you have kept in your heart.”

32 Then conviction arose in Śivānanda’s mind, and he showed him great respect and much devotion.

33 Such is the inconceivable power of Mahāprabhu. Now hear how the Lord’s ‘āvirbhāva’ (appearance) takes place.

34–35 In Śacī’s house, at Nityānanda’s dancing, at Śrīvāsa’s kīrtana and in Rāghava’s home — in these four places the Lord always makes His ‘āvirbhāva’. He is drawn by prema: that is the Lord’s innate nature.

36 Appearing before Nṛsiṁhānanda, He took a meal. Hear of it attentively.

37 Śivānanda’s nephew was named Śrīkānta Sena; by the Lord’s mercy he was most fortunate.

38 One year he came for the first time, alone, to see the Lord, his heart full of longing.

39 When Mahāprabhu saw him, He showed him great mercy, and he stayed near the Lord for about two months.

40 Then the Lord ordered him to go to Gauḍa, and He forbade the devotees to come here:

41 “This year I shall go there Myself, and there I shall meet everyone — Advaita and all the others.

42 Tell Śivānanda that this month of Pauṣa I shall certainly come to him unexpectedly.

43 Jagadānanda is there; he will give Me bhikṣā (feed Me). And tell everyone that no one is to come this year."

44 Śrīkānta came to Gauḍa and delivered the message, and when the devotees heard it, their hearts were filled with joy.

45 Advaita Ācārya, who had been setting out, stayed where He was, and Śivānanda and Jagadānanda remained, waiting in expectation.

46 When the month of Pauṣa came, the two of them made all the preparations and waited until evening.

47 In this way the month passed, and the Lord did not come. Jagadānanda and Śivānanda became sorrowful.

48 Unexpectedly Nṛsiṁhānanda arrived there. The two of them received him and gave him a seat.

49 Seeing them both unhappy, Nṛsiṁhānanda said to them, "Why do I see you both so joyless?"

50 Then Śivānanda told him everything: "The Lord gave His word that He would come. Why has He not come?"

51 Hearing this, the brahmacārī said, "Be content. I shall bring Him on the third day."

52 Both of them knew his power and his prema, and they were certain in their minds that he would now bring the Lord.

53 His own name was Pradyumna Brahmacārī; it was Gaura, the abode of all, who named him Nṛsiṁhānanda.

54 After meditating for two days, he said to Śivānanda, “I have brought the Lord to the village of Pāṇihāṭi.

55 Tomorrow at noon He will come to your house. Bring the provisions for cooking; I shall give Him bhikṣā.

56 Then I shall quickly bring Him here. I tell you this with certainty — have no doubt at all.

57 Whatever I require, provide it promptly. I shall cook very quickly. Listen further:

58 bring the provisions for cooking, whatever I want.” Whatever he asked for, Śivānanda brought and gave him.

59 From early morning he cooked without limit: many kinds of soup and vegetable dishes, cakes, and offerings of sweet rice.

60 He served out a distinct offering separately for Jagannātha, and he made another offering for Caitanya Prabhu.

61 He served out a separate offering for his worshipful Deity, Nṛsiṁha. Having offered the food to all three, he sat outside and meditated.

62 He saw Caitanya Gosāñi quickly come and sit down. He ate all three offerings, and nothing was left.

63 Overwhelmed with bliss, Pradyumna shed streams of tears, and he cried out, “Alas, alas! What are You doing?

64 You and Jagannātha are one, so You may eat His offering. But why do You consume Nṛsiṁha's offering?

65 I see that today Nṛsiṁha has had to fast. If the master goes without food, how can his servant live?"

66 Although his heart rejoiced at seeing the Lord eat, outwardly, for Nṛsiṁha's sake, he made some show of sorrow.

67 Kṛṣṇa Caitanya Gosāñi is Svayaṁ Bhagavān, the Supreme Lord Himself: between Him and Jagannātha and Nṛsiṁha there is no difference at all.

68 Pradyumna had a secret wish to know this, and by eating the Lord showed it to him.

69 Having eaten, the Lord went to Pāṇihāṭi, pleased by the excellence of the dishes.

70 Śivānanda said, "Why are you crying out?" The brahmacārī said, "Look at the Lord's conduct!

71 He alone has eaten the offerings meant for all three, and Jagannātha and Nṛsiṁha have been left fasting."

72 Hearing this, doubt arose in Śivānanda's mind: was he speaking in the ecstasy of prema, or was it true?

73 Then the brahmacārī said to Śivānanda, "Bring the provisions; I shall cook for Nṛsiṁha once more."

74 Śivānanda then brought the provisions for the offering, and the brahmacārī cooked and offered the food to Nṛsiṁha.

75 The following year Śivānanda took the devotees to Nīlācala and saw the Lord's feet.

76 One day, in the assembly, the Lord brought up the subject and began to speak of Nṛsiṁhānanda's virtues:

77 "Last year, in Pauṣa, he fed Me. Never have I eaten such sweets and vegetable dishes."

78 Hearing this, the devotees were filled with wonder, and then conviction was born in Śivānanda's mind.

79 In the same way He constantly takes His meals in Śacī's house, and in Śrīvāsa's house He watches the kīrtana.

80 Again and again He comes to watch Nityānanda's dancing, and in Rāghava's house His 'āvirbhāva' is constant.

81 Gaura Prabhu is controlled by prema: wherever there is the highest prema, there, controlled by it, He gives His darśana.

82 Who can tell the full extent of Śivānanda's prema? Controlled by his prema, the Lord comes to him again and again.

83 Thus I have told of Gaura's 'āvirbhāva'. Whoever hears of it comes to know Caitanya's power.

84 In Puruṣottama, near the Lord, lived Bhagavān Ācārya, a supreme Vaiṣṇava, very learned and noble.

85 His heart was filled with the mood of friendship (sakhya); he was an incarnation of a cowherd boy, and with Svarūpa Gosāñi he dealt as a friend.

86 He had taken shelter at Caitanya's feet with single-minded devotion, and from time to time he would invite the Lord for a meal.

87 At home he would cook rice and make many kinds of vegetable dishes, and he would bring the Lord alone and feed Him.

88 His father, Śatānanda Khān, was a great man of worldly affairs, but the Ācārya had turned away from worldly things: renunciation was foremost in him.

89 His younger brother, named Gopāla Bhaṭṭācārya, studied Vedānta in Kāśī and then came to the Ācārya.

90 The Ācārya brought him to the Lord's feet, but the Lord, who knows every heart, found no happiness within.

91 Because Gopāla was related to the Ācārya, the Lord outwardly showed him a semblance of affection; but without devotion to Kṛṣṇa the Lord feels no joy.

92 One day the Ācārya said to Svarūpa Gosāñi, "Gopāla has come here after studying Vedānta.

93 Let us all come together and hear the commentary from him." Showing loving anger, Svarūpa replied:

94 "Your intelligence has been spoiled in Gopāla's company, and you have taken a fancy to hear Māyāvāda.

95 A Vaiṣṇava who listens to the *Śārīraka-bhāṣya* gives up the relationship of servant and served and considers himself the Lord.

96 Even a *mahā-bhāgavata*, whose treasure of life is Kṛṣṇa, will surely have his heart turned by hearing Māyāvāda.”

97 The Ācārya said, “Our hearts are fixed on Kṛṣṇa; a commentary cannot turn our minds.”

98 Svarūpa said, “Even so, in hearing Māyāvāda one hears only this: ‘Brahman is pure consciousness, and *māyā* is false;

99 the very notion of the *jīva* is imaginary, and in the Lord there is nothing but ignorance.’ Hearing this, a devotee’s heart and soul break.”

100 Ashamed and afraid, the Ācārya fell silent, and the next day he sent Gopāla back to his native place.

101 One day the Ācārya invited the Lord. At home he cooked rice and made various vegetable dishes.

102 The Lord had a singer named Choṭa Haridāsa. The Ācārya called him, brought him to himself and said,

103 “Go in my name to Śikhi Māhiti’s sister, ask her for one *māna* of white rice and bring it.”

104 Māhiti’s sister was named Mādhavī-devī. She was elderly, given to austerity, and a supreme Vaiṣṇavī.

105 The Lord counted her among Rādhikā’s associates. In all the world there are only three and a half such worthy persons:

106 Svarūpa Gosāñi, Rāmānanda Rāya and Śikhi Māhiti are the three, and his sister is the half.

107 Haridāsa begged the rice from her and brought it, and when the Ācārya saw the rice he was overjoyed.

108 With affection he cooked the dishes the Lord loved, and set out *prasāda* from the temple, slices of ginger, and lime with salt.

109 At midday the Lord came and sat down to eat. Seeing the fine rice, the Lord asked the Ācārya,

110 “Where did you get such rice for this excellent dish?” The Ācārya said, “It was begged from Mādhavī and brought here.”

111 The Lord said, “Who went and begged it?” The Ācārya named Choṭa Haridāsa.

112 Praising the rice, the Lord took His meal. Then, returning to His residence, He gave Govinda an order:

113 “From today you must keep this order of Mine: do not let Choṭa Haridāsa come here.”

114 The door was barred to him, and Haridāsa grew sorrowful at heart. No one knew why the door was barred.

115 Haridāsa fasted for three days. Then Svarūpa and all the others came to the Lord and asked,

116 “O Lord, what offence has Haridāsa committed? Why is the door barred to him? He is fasting.”

117 The Lord said, “A renunciant who converses with women — I cannot bear to see his face.

118 The senses are hard to restrain and seize their objects; even a woman made of wood steals the mind of a sage.

119 “One should not sit in a secluded place even with one’s mother, sister or daughter, for the powerful senses drag away even a learned man.” (Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam, 9.19.17; Manu-saṁhitā, 2.215)

120 Petty souls adopt a monkey’s renunciation and wander about, letting their senses graze and conversing with women.”

121 Saying this, Mahāprabhu went inside. Seeing the Lord so stirred, everyone fell silent.

122 The next day they all came together to the Lord’s feet and made a petition on Haridāsa’s behalf:

123 “It is a small offence, O Lord; be gracious to him. He has learned his lesson now and will not offend again.”

124 The Lord said, “My mind is not under My control: it will not look upon a renunciant who converses with women.

125 Go, all of you, to your own duties and give up this useless talk. If you speak of it again, you will not see Me here.”

126 Hearing this, everyone covered their ears with their hands, rose and went off to their own duties.

127 Mahāprabhu went off to perform His midday duties. No one can understand this pastime of Mahāprabhu.

128 The next day they all went to Paramānanda Purī and petitioned him, “Please make the Lord pleased again.”

129 Then Purī Gosāñi came alone to the Lord. The Lord bowed to him and seated him with reverence.

130 The Lord asked, “What is your order? Why have you come?” Purī Gosāñi petitioned Him to show grace to Haridāsa.

131 Hearing this, the Lord said, “Listen, Gosāñi: stay here with all the Vaiṣṇavas,

132 and give Me leave to go to Ālālanātha. I will stay there alone, with only Govinda.”

133 Saying this, the Lord called Govinda, bowed to Purī, rose and set off.

134 In great haste Purī Gosāñi went before the Lord and, humbly entreating Him, brought Him back into the house.

135 “Do whatever You wish: You are the independent Lord. Who can tell You anything?

136 All Your dealings are for the good of the people. None of us can know Your deep heart.”

137 Saying this, Purī Gosāñi went back to his own place, and all the devotees went to Haridāsa.

138 Svarūpa Gosāñi said, “Listen, Haridāsa: we all wish you well — believe this.

139 The Lord, the independent Lord, has set His will firmly; but in time He will show mercy, for His heart is merciful.

140 If you are stubborn, His stubbornness will only grow. If you bathe and eat, His anger will pass of itself.”

141 Saying this, Svarūpa had him bathe and eat, reassured him, and returned to his own residence.

142 Whenever the Lord went to see Jagannātha, Haridāsa would see Him from a distance.

143 Mahāprabhu is an ocean of mercy — who can understand Him? He punishes His own devotee to make people understand *dharma*.

144 Seeing this, all the devotees were struck with fear, and even in their dreams they gave up talking with women.

145 In this way a year passed for Haridāsa, yet no grace toward him arose in Mahāprabhu’s mind.

146 At the end of the night he offered prostrate obeisances to the Lord and went to Prayāga without saying anything to anyone.

147 Resolving to attain the Lord’s feet, he entered the Triveṇī and gave up his body.

148 At that very moment he came to the Lord in a divine body, and, having received the Lord’s mercy, he remained invisible.

149 In the body of a Gandharva he sang invisibly. At night he would let the Lord hear his songs, and no one else knew.

150 One day Mahāprabhu asked the devotees, “Where is Haridāsa? Bring him here.”

151 They all said, “On the day the year was completed, Haridāsa rose in the night and went away. No one knows where.”

152 Hearing this, Mahāprabhu only smiled a little, and all the devotees were filled with wonder.

153–154 One day Jagadānanda, Svarūpa, Govinda, Kāśīśvara, Śaṅkara, Dāmodara and Mukunda went to bathe in the sea, and some distance away they heard Haridāsa singing, as if calling out at the top of his voice.

155 They saw no one; they heard only the sweet song. Govinda and the others together began to guess:

156 “Haridāsa must have taken poison or something like it and killed himself, and by that sin, we think, he has become a *brahma-rākṣasa*.

157 We see no form; we only hear his song.” Svarūpa said, “This guess is false.

158 From his birth he sang of Kṛṣṇa and served the Lord; he was a recipient of the Lord’s mercy, and he left his body in a holy place.

159 No evil end can be his; his end is a blessed one. This is the Lord’s way — later you will know it for certain.”

160 A Vaiṣṇava came from Prayāga to Navadvīpa and told everyone the news of Haridāsa —

161 how he had made his resolve and how he had entered the Triveṇī. Hearing this, Śrīvāsa and the others were filled with wonder.

162 The next year Śivānanda brought all the devotees and came, full of joy, to meet the Lord.

163 When Śrīvāsa asked, “Where is Haridāsa?” the Lord answered, “A man reaps the fruit of his own deeds.”

164 Then Śrīvāsa told his story: how he had made his resolve and how he had entered the Triveṇī.

165 Hearing this, the Lord smiled and, His heart well pleased, said, “For one who looks at women, this is the atonement.”

166 Then Svarūpa and the others met and considered it: by the power of the Triveṇī, Haridāsa had come to the Lord.

167 Such are the pastimes of the son of Śacī; hearing of them, the devotees’ ears and hearts are soothed.

168 His own compassion; the teaching of renunciation to the world; the revealing of the deep love of His own devotee;

169 the glory of the holy place; and the taking of His own devotee as His own — through a single pastime the Lord accomplishes five or seven purposes.

170 The sweet pastimes of Caitanya are as deep as the ocean. People in general do not understand them; only one who is a devotee and steady in mind understands.

171 Hear the deeds of Caitanya with faith. Do not argue: argument will bring the opposite result.

172 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.